ERA 23

The Post–Cold War World

1991 – 2001

The 1990s · the Gulf War · Clinton · the digital revolution

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did the end of the Cold War and the rise of the Internet reshape America and the world?

KEY TERMS

The Persian Gulf War · globalization · NAFTA · the digital revolution

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 9.3–9.4 · AMSCO Ch. 9.3–9.4

AMERICA ALONE AT THE TOP

A New World Order

A New Era

I

The Sole Superpower

With the USSR gone, the U.S. stood unrivaled in power.

II

The Persian Gulf War

A U.S.-led coalition drove Iraq out of Kuwait in 1991—a swift victory.

III

A Wave of Globalization

Trade, technology, and capital flowed across a more connected world.

The Digital Revolution

- The **personal computer** moved from the office into the home.
- By the late 1990s, the **Internet** and **World Wide Web** connected the world.
- A **dot-com boom** transformed business and communication.



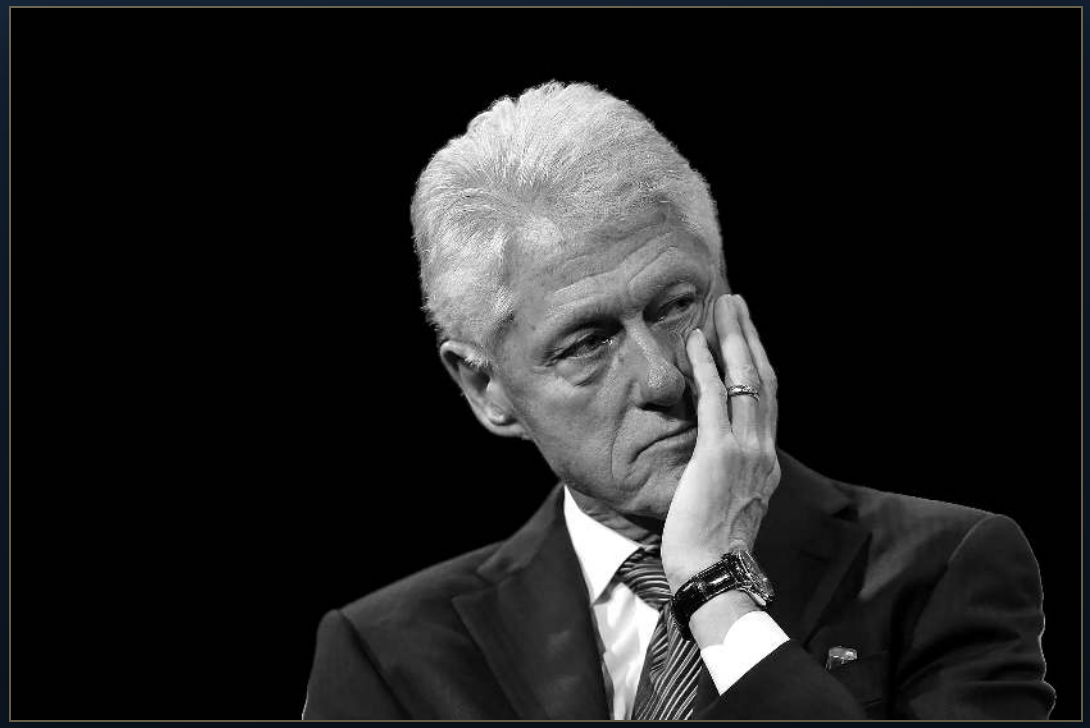
The Internet Economy



- New companies like Amazon and eBay reinvented how Americans shopped.
- Email and the web sped up business and everyday life.
- The U.S. led a new **information economy**.

The Clinton Years

- **Bill Clinton** presided over the longest economic boom in U.S. history.
- He championed **free trade**, signing **NAFTA** in 1994.
- The federal budget swung from deficits to surplus.



Globalization & Its Discontents



- **Free trade** and **outsourcing** sent manufacturing jobs overseas.
- **Deindustrialization** hollowed out the industrial Midwest.
- The boom masked rising **income inequality** and stagnant wages for many.

The 1990s at Home

LAW

Defense of Marriage Act (DOMA) (1996)

Signed by President Clinton, it defined marriage for federal purposes as between a man and a woman and let states refuse to recognize same-sex marriages from other states. The Supreme Court struck it down in 2013 and 2015.

EVENT

Oklahoma City bombing (1995)

Timothy McVeigh, an anti-government extremist, bombed the Murrah Federal Building, killing 168 people. It remains one of the deadliest acts of domestic terrorism in U.S. history.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Post–Cold War World

1. The end of the Cold War left the U.S. the **sole superpower**, tested in the swift **Persian Gulf War**.
2. The **digital revolution**—the PC and the **Internet**—reshaped the economy and daily life.
3. **Clinton's** boom and **globalization** brought prosperity, but also **outsourcing** and rising **inequality**.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Post–Cold War World

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how the **digital revolution** transformed the American economy and daily life.

COMPARISON

Compare the benefits and costs of **globalization** for different groups of Americans.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did America's role in the world **change** after the Cold War?

Up next — **Lesson 56: The War on Terror** (9/11 & a new era of conflict)